

In a 2015 article in the *New York Times*, author Lee Siegel admitted that he'd chosen to purposefully default on his student loans. (He faced a ton of controversy for this stance and went on various media outlets to defend himself.) "It struck me as absurd," Siegel wrote, "that one could amass crippling debt as a result, not of drug addiction or reckless borrowing and spending, but of going to college. Having opened a new life to me beyond my modest origins, the education system was now going to call in its chits and prevent me from pursuing that new life, simply because I had the misfortune of coming from modest origins."

Like Ariza following her father's wish for her to "rise above" their immigrant status, Siegel said loans discourage young people from trying to rise above their "lower-middle-class origins" and maintain the wealth status quo using education as leverage. "To my mind, they have learned to live with a social arrangement that is legal, but not moral," he wrote of those paying back their loans. Ariza continues to pay off her loans in small amounts, but she's living paycheck to paycheck like most of her friends. She has immediate concerns like bills and rent to consider.

"If you begin to think about it, it leads to like, a panic attack," she said.

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Community college, which for many people is free, can be a good financial buffer and a segue into independence. Students I interviewed at Palm Beach State College (a community college in Florida) in 2017 were largely happy with their choice of school. They were all excited to graduate without a lot of (or any!) debt and they felt badly for their peers who had chosen more expensive schools, hoping to be guaranteed better jobs.

Many of these students knew what they wanted to do and that an associate's degree was enough. Some didn't know yet and didn't want to pay for a four-year university just to find out. Many also didn't want to pay for housing, and so they lived at home to save money or to help their parents care for their siblings—wanting to continue contributing to the household rather than becoming a